Designing a Structured Onboarding Framework to Improve Time-to-Effectiveness for Security Engineering Teams

Initial Interview Instructions

This process should take no more than 15-20 minutes to complete. Just enter your feedback for questions into this document. When you are done, please save and email to dishner@gmail.com. If you have any questions, feel free to reach out to me to get clarification. I welcome any additional feedback beyond the listed questions that you wish to provide.

Purpose of These Interviews

These interviews are designed to gather qualitative insights from key stakeholder groups to inform my Cybersecurity Practicum project. The goal is to understand current onboarding experiences, pain points, and success factors that influence how quickly a security engineer becomes a confident, contributing member of the team.

This document is semi-structured: the questions below provide a guide, but I welcome tangents, examples, and stories that feel relevant. You only need to answer the questions that apply to the role you are in - leadership/management, experienced team member, or recent joiner - but if you can provide feedback in another section, feel free to as all feedback is appreciated.

Insights will be synthesized across stakeholder groups to identify common themes, gaps, and opportunities. Individual responses will not be attributed by name.

Designing a Structured Onboarding Framework to Improve Time-to-Effectiveness for Security Engineering Teams

Project Proposal

Dustin Dishner

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Security engineering teams design, review, and implement controls that protect critical systems and data across diverse environments. These environments often include cloud infrastructure, identity platforms, custom developed applications, and layered security solutions. As organizations scale to meet these increasing security demands, new team members are onboarded with different backgrounds. They bring with them varying levels of familiarity with architectures, workflows, and threat models. Effective onboarding is essential to maintaining operational continuity and reducing security risk.

Despite its importance, onboarding within security engineering teams is often informal, inconsistent, and highly dependent on sharing of tribal knowledge. New hires are expected to get up to speed through ad hoc documentation and reaching out to peers for assistance. This approach creates uncertainty for the new hire and can delay a new team member's ability to meaningfully contribute to their new team.

The core problem addressed by this project is the absence of a structured and repeatable onboarding framework tailored specifically to security engineering teams that measurably reduces time-to-effectiveness. In many organizations, onboarding depends on individual initiative or the availability of informal mentorship rather than a clearly defined process. This lack of structure introduces operational and security risk by extending ramp-up periods, reducing team velocity, and increasing the likelihood of misconfigurations, particularly in high-impact areas such as identity and access management and cloud security. Over time, reliance on undocumented knowledge also increases reliance on key individuals, contributes to burnout, and negatively affects team morale, retention and overall security posture.

MOTIVATION

I am motivated to pursue this project because improving onboarding effectiveness for security engineering teams represents a high-impact opportunity to improve security outcomes without significant investment in new technology or tools. While many organizations acknowledge the importance of onboarding, existing processes are often generalized, undocumented, or adapted from software engineering models that do not fully account for the unique responsibilities, risk exposure, and decision-making demands of security engineering roles. Security teams are expected to scale rapidly in response to evolving threats and regulatory pressure. Ineffective onboarding limits their ability to meet these demands.

My interest in this problem stems from personal experience joining a new security engineering team. Three years ago, when I transitioned from a previous employer to my current position, I experienced firsthand the challenges created by a lack of structured onboarding for security engineering roles. Although general corporate onboarding and access provisioning were in place, there was no clear, role-specific framework to guide my understanding of security architecture, workflows, or expectations. As a result, achieving meaningful contribution required significant self-directed effort and reliance on informal mentorship.

In addition to my experience in security engineering domains such as identity and access management and security architecture, I have formal training in productivity methodologies, process improvement, and organizational management. This background allows me to approach onboarding as an operational system rather than a one-time training activity. Academically, this project aligns with the objectives of the Cybersecurity Practicum by applying cybersecurity theory, risk management principles, and organization process design into a real-word problem The goal is to produce practical, reusable artifacts that integrate academic learning with professional practice and can be adapted by other security engineering teams facing similar challenges.

EXPECTED DELIVERABLES

Inventory of Current Process: I will be working with my personal contacts in management from as many organizations as I can to document all of the steps they currently follow whether documented or not. This will give a starting point for process development.

Stakeholder Interview Summary: Interviews will be performed with stakeholders (recent joiners, long-term team members, and management) from several organizations I have contacts in to gather feedback concerning perceived gaps in the onboarding experience, difficulties in knowledge transfer, and suggestions for improvement. These interviews will include assessment of perception of current time-to-effectiveness.

Cybersecurity Team Onboarding Framework: A structured generalized framework outlining onboarding phases (30/60/90 days), knowledge transfer activities, networking within and outside the team, access alignment, and role clarity.

Feedback on Framework from Stakeholders: After creating the framework, I will validate the framework by gathering retrospective feedback from the various stakeholders on how they believe the framework would impact the onboarding process, including recommendations for future iteration or adoption. This will be done using qualitative scoring surveys on each included item in the framework to assess value, because quantitative measurement is hard to achieve with hypothetical improvements. An assessment of the perceived time-to-effectiveness using the framework will be gathered as well.

Initial Interview Questions

Leadership/Management

The goal of the questions in this section is to understand leadership expectations, perceived onboarding challenges, risk tolerance, and how success is currently measured for new joiners.

If you are able to provide sanitized versions (no user info or product names) of onboarding checklists/documentation, it would be greatly appreciated. I am including them in the appendix of the final report as an example of what exists today.

1. What does "successful onboarding" look like for a security engineer on your team?

2. How quickly do you expect a new hire to contribute meaningfully?

3. Is there a defined onboarding process today? If so, how consistently is it followed?

4. What parts of onboarding are undocumented or informal?

5. Where does poor onboarding create the most risk for your team or organization?

6. Are there dependencies on specific individuals to onboard new hires effectively?

7. How do you currently assess whether onboarding has been successful?

8. Do you track time-to-effectiveness in any formal or informal way?

9. What elements would be essential in a standardized onboarding framework?

10. What concerns would you have about adopting a generalized onboarding framework?

11. How would you expect such a framework to improve outcomes for your team?

12. If you could change one thing about the onboarding experience, what would it be?

Additional Feedback:

Experienced Team Member

The goal of this interview is to understand the peer and mentorship role in onboarding and knowledge transfer, by identifying tribal knowledge, hidden dependencies, and expectations placed on new hires.

It may be early enough in your career that you still remember the onboarding process you went through. If so, please consider filling out the new joiner section as well. This may help identify how the process has changed over time.

1. How long have you been on this security engineering team?

2. Do you regularly support onboarding new team members (Yes/Occasionally/No)?

3. In your experience, where do new hires struggle the most?

4. What knowledge or skills do new hires consistently lack when they start?

5. What information do new hires usually learn informally rather than from documentation?

6. On average, how long does it take for a new hire to become fully productive?

7. What signals tell you that a new hire is up to speed?

8. Are there areas where poor onboarding creates security or operational risk?

9. Are there tasks you hesitate to hand off to new hires early on? Why?

10. What should every security engineer understand within their first 30/60/90 days?

11. What onboarding steps would you standardize if you could?

12. If you could change one thing about the onboarding experience, what would it be?

Additional Feedback:

New Joiner

The goal of this interview is to capture the lived experience of onboarding from the perspective of someone who recently went through it to understand onboarding gaps, confusion points, and ramp-up blockers from lived experience.

1. What was your role and background before joining this team?

2. How familiar were you with the organization's security stack before starting (Very familiar/Somewhat/Not at all)?

3. How clear were your responsibilities and expectations during your first 30 days?

4. What resources were most helpful during onboarding?

5. What information did you struggle to find or wish existed?

6. How long did it take before you felt you were meaningfully contributing to the team?

7. What specifically helped you reach that point?

8. What slowed you down the most?

9. Were there any onboarding steps that felt ad hoc or dependent on who you asked?

10. What would have made your onboarding experience more efficient?

11. If there had been a 30/60/90-day onboarding plan, what would you have expected it to include?

12. If you could change one thing about the onboarding experience, what would it be?

Additional Feedback:

Thank you for agreeing to participate in this project. Your assistance is greatly appreciated. I will reach out when I am ready to do the framework review and feedback survey.